

Tumultuous fall ahead for Merz government

送信者: EG Europe 受信日時: 2026-09-01 22:30

[【メール原文】](#)

On 6 September, the far-right AfD will double its share of the vote but likely fail to win an outright majority in its strongest electoral market in G|||||||

Germany

[Customize Email Preferences](#)

AfD victory in Saxony-Anhalt heralds tumultuous fall for Merz

1 Sep 2026 09:28 EDT [Discover more on the Portal](#)

Short-term trajectory:

Long-term trajectory:

*

The far-right Alternative for Germany (AfD) will score strongly but likely miss an outright majority in the upcoming state elections on 6 September in the eastern state of Saxony-Anhalt, and will also not find political allies to form a government.

*

Strong AfD results in all three September state elections, in combination with weak numbers for both the CDU and SPD, will increase the infighting in both parties, even though leadership challenges or government collapse remain unlikely this year (a 20% probability).

*

Parliamentary implementation of the July pension deal that had stabilized the Merz government will likely be divisive and complicated, potentially watering down the government's only major legislative achievement.

On 6 September, the far-right AfD will double its share of the vote but likely fail to win an outright majority in its strongest electoral market in Germany, the eastern state of Saxony-Anhalt. Recent polling data indicates that the AfD lost some steam after an uninterrupted, multi-year rise in the polls. We put the AfD's chances of gaining an outright majority at 20%. The CDU will come in second, followed by the Left Party. The SPD will very likely stay solidly above 5% after having regained some strength in recent weeks, while the Greens will just about clear the 5% hurdle.

Government formation will be highly complicated, likely leading to a minority coalition of CDU, SPD, and Greens, supported by the Left Party (a 60% probability). The AfD's hope to convince defectors from the CDU or other parties to help vote an AfD state prime minister into office will likely be disappointed (a 15% probability). The probability of the AfD forming a government with the BSW, a left-wing party that recently made overtures to the AfD, stands at only 5%, as the BSW will most likely fail to enter parliament. All other parties have vowed not to cooperate with the AfD. The probability of new elections is low (10%), as all other parties must fear that in the highly polarized political atmosphere in Saxony-Anhalt, a re-run would catapult the AfD to an absolute majority. Coalition talks will likely commence only after the state elections in Mecklenburg-Western Pomerania and Berlin on 20 September.

All three September state elections will deliver significant blows to both the CDU and SPD. The votes in Saxony-Anhalt, Mecklenburg-Western Pomerania, and Berlin (both on 20 September) will likely cost the CDU power in Saxony-Anhalt and Berlin. The SPD is bound to suffer major setbacks in all three votes and could even fail to re-enter parliament in Saxony-Anhalt—the party's worst-case scenario.

The state votes will likely deepen the leadership crisis in both the CDU and SPD. Disgruntlement in both parties over weak leadership, too many compromises, and too few legislative achievements has undermined the authority of Merz (CDU) and of Klingbeil and Bas (both SPD). In both parties, sizable portions of the all-important mid-layer of party functionaries and activists are now openly questioning their respective leaderships, whose main goal is to keep the governing coalition from falling apart. The expected poor results for both parties in the state elections will likely accelerate these dynamics. Overall, the structural weaknesses of a marriage of convenience between two parties at opposite ends of the ideological spectrum will become increasingly visible.

Leadership challenges remain unlikely in both parties, but can no longer be ruled out completely. Such a development is more likely in the SPD than in the CDU. Recent polling presents a more existential risk for the SPD than for the CDU, and the SPD has traditionally been a more rebellious party, willing to undermine and damage its own leadership. A palace revolt is seen as too costly by most Social Democrats, but a small number of SPD insurgents hopes to convene a special party congress after the fall state elections to remove Klingbeil and Bas as chairs. Merz is somewhat shielded by his role as chancellor, making a move against him less likely. His biggest rival, and possible successor, Hendrik Wüst, the prime minister of North Rhine-Westphalia, Germany's largest and most consequential state politically, is unlikely to make a move before his own state elections in April of 2027.

Eurasia Group assigns only a 20% probability to government collapse before the end of the year. The government would likely survive a change of leadership in either or both parties. Early elections are unlikely, as both sides fear the considerable losses they would face. Within the current parliament, there is no viable alternative to the current majority.

Implementing the pension compromise brokered in July will be the key litmus test for government productivity this year and into 2027. The deal had stabilized the government after months of uncertainty (please see Eurasia Group note Germany: Reform deal significantly reduces odds of government breakdown , 27 July 2026), but has been under attack since its inception from both within the coalition and the opposition. The package's parliamentary ratification, running parallel to the 2027 budget negotiations, will likely devolve into complicated renegotiations and horse-trading that could unravel or dilute the outcome.

Jan Techau
Director, Europe
Techau.ne@eurasiagroup.net
EG Europe
europe@eurasiagroup.net

© 2026 Eurasia Group. All rights reserved. This material was produced by Eurasia Group for use by the recipient. This is intended as general background research and is not intended to constitute advice on any particular commercial investment or trade matter or issue and should not be relied upon for such

purposes. It is not to be made available to any person other than the recipient. No part of this publication may be reproduced, stored in a retrieval system, or transmitted in any form or by any means, electronic or otherwise, without the prior consent of Eurasia Group.

X-HG-DocID cmtikerylicpy07mwb1kcy4e6

[Opt Out](#) | [Customize Email Preferences](#)